Cleaning and Structuring Historical Data

Working sheet · Jim Clifford · 15 October 2026

Mark up Balmer

Colonial Office List, 1936, Record of Services. OCR excerpt, entry `col1936-p832b11`. A source reference lets us return to the page; the OCR is not the page image.

> BALMER, F. E.—Dep. chief acctnt., G.P.O., E. Africa Prot., Mar., 1919; ch. acctnt., G.P.O., Kenya, Oct., 1919; ch. acctnt., Kenya-Uganda-Tanganyika post and tel. service, 1933; senr. dep. P.M.G., do., 1935.

Three minutes: underline the last two positions, circle their places and box their years. What does "do." refer to? How would you record that the place was inherited?

My decision and reason:

The target is one event per posting: position, place, start and end year, acting status, and whether the place was inherited. Keep the source reference and printed wording alongside the interpretation.

A second entry for later

Colonial Office List, 1889, entry `col1889-p554b20`.

> TRIMEN, HENRY, M.B. (Lond.), F.R.S., F.L.S. —Formerly lecturer on botany at St. Mary's Hospital, London, 1867 to 1875; was senior assistant to department of botany, British Museum, 1869 to 1879; director Royal Botanical Gardens, Ceylon, Feb., 1880; author of numerous works and papers on pure and applied botany.

Two appointments overlap. Should the record preserve both? Is "British Museum" an institution, a location, or both for your research question?

Keep the decisions visible

Question	Decision
Structure	What counts as an event?
Clean	Merge, keep apart, or review?
Ground	Supported, unresolved, or wrong?

Build. Extract. Visualise. See. Fix. Rerun.

Your data: what counts as a record in your collection?

Site, exercises and worked answers: **jimclifford.ca/imperial-careers-workshop**

Three decisions with reasons

Take six minutes. Choose **accept**, **reject**, or **unresolved** for each proposal. Give the evidence that decided it; if unresolved, say what you would check. We will discuss R8 together.

R1 · Blakely

Source, *Colonial Office List* 1905: "BLAKELY, DONALD QUENTIN.—Clk., atty.-gen.'s off., B. Honduras, Apl., 1898."

Proposal: birth year 1898; one posting, "Clk., atty.-gen.'s officer", in B. Honduras, with no event year.

The place and position are recognisable, and the model was told to extract only printed facts. But the entry has no birth clause; its date belongs to the appointment. "Off." means office here.

Decision and reason: _____

R3 · Abery and Carbery

ABERY, Joseph: M.B.C.M.; 1867 Ceylon, assistant colonial surgeon; one edition (1897).

CARBERY, Joseph: M.B.C.M.; same dated appointment; six editions, including 1897.

Proposal: merge the biographies. The forename, qualification and appointment agree, and the shorter surname could be an OCR loss. Against: the surnames differ, and one shared event may need corroboration.

Decision and reason: _____

R8 · Harris

Source, *Colonial Office List* 1927 (OCR excerpt; omissions marked): "HARRIS, SIR CHARLES ALEXANDER … B. 1858; scholar, prizeman, and Porteus medallist of Christ's Coll., Camb.; … gov. and c. in c., Newfoundland, 1st Nov., 1917; assumed govt., 17th Dec., 1917; ret., 1922."

The retrieved Charles Alexander Harris item names Christ's College and the Newfoundland governorship, but gives birth in **1855**.

Proposal: accept the identity link, preserve **1858** as the source reading, record **1855** separately and flag the disagreement.

The name, college and office agree. The dates conflict; the OCR alone cannot tell us whether the discrepancy began in scanning, printing or the external record. The accounts may also share an underlying source.

Decision and reason: _____

Next evidence to check: _____

Accepting an identity and correcting a source are separate decisions.